Triple Scoring — 2026-05-11 — AXEL Variations

Note on Buildability: AXEL is a non-trivial roguelite (cascade physics, item synergies, RTP balancing, run loop, art). Pipeline's default "hours-to-build" rubric is inapplicable. Scores adjusted to roguelite-realistic timelines:

- 9–10 = 1–2 weeks solo (emoji/CSS prototype)
- 7–8 = 3–4 weeks solo (vector, proven framework)
- 5–6 = 4–7 weeks solo or small team (pixel art needed)
- 3–4 = 8+ weeks team (custom engine, multiplayer, full polish)

ALL Variations Scored (by Combined Score)

Rank	Variation	V	B	M	Combined	Team	Trend	Mon Model	Tier	Decision
1	AXEL: ZERO (1.5)	7.0	9.0	5.5	**7.2**	Solo	Rising	Free web + future IAP	1	**BUILD NOW** (validation)
2	AXEL: Resonance (1.2)	8.0	6.5	7.0	**7.3**	Solo	Rising/Peak	Premium PC + mobile F2P	1	**BUILD** (full release)
3	AXEL: Tilt (1.4)	8.0	5.5	7.0	**6.9**	Solo+	Rising/Peak	Premium PC + DLC biomes	2	**BUILD** (alt narrative)
4	AXEL: Grease (1.1)	8.0	4.5	7.0	**6.5**	Small team	Peak	Premium PC	3	**TEAM REVIEW** (pixel art)

Rank	Variation	V	B	M	Combined	Team	Trend	Mon Model	Tier	Decision
5	AXEL: Sigil (1.3)	7.0	4.5	6.0	**6.0**	Small team	Saturated	Premium PC	4	**TEST** or SKIP (crowded)

Combined formula: `(0.45 × V) + (0.30 × B) + (0.25 × M)`

BY TIER

TIER 1: BUILD NOW (Combined ≥ 7.0, Solo)

AXEL: ZERO — Combined 7.2 (V:7.0 B:9.0 M:5.5)

- **Strategy:** Ship in 1–2 weeks as web prototype. Validates K-factor + cascade clip-virality BEFORE the full AXEL investment.
- **Monetization:** Free / browser at first. If K > 0.5, add "remove ads" purchase or premium-skin layer.
- **Why now:** Smallest possible bet on the trend wave. Doubles as a marketing funnel.

AXEL: Resonance — Combined 7.3 (V:8.0 B:6.5 M:7.0)

- **Strategy:** Full Steam release 3–4 weeks after ZERO ships, IF ZERO validates the hook.
- **Monetization:** Premium PC $9.99–$14.99 (matches LBL/CloverPit/Slots & Daggers pricing) + mobile F2P port later with rewarded ads.
- **Why now:** Vector visual lane unoccupied. Solo-buildable. Distinct from CloverPit-grunge.

TIER 2: BUILD (Combined 6.5–7.0)

AXEL: Tilt — Combined 6.9

- **Strategy:** Alternative theme if narrative angle tests better than cosmic. Same mechanics, different framing.
- **Monetization:** Premium PC + DLC heist biomes.

TIER 3: SMALL TEAM (Buildability 4–5)

AXEL: Grease — Combined 6.5

- Best zeitgeist fit but pixel art creates art-team dependency. Worth discussing if your friend has access to a pixel artist.

TIER 4: TEST / SKIP

AXEL: Sigil — Combined 6.0

- Crowded against Slots & Daggers / Runeborn / Slot & Dungeons. SKIP unless unique fantasy angle.

TOP 3 DETAILED BREAKDOWN

#1 AXEL: ZERO — VALIDATION PROTOTYPE

Virality 7.0 — Strong cascade-clip moment, daily-seed leaderboard, auto-share card. Lower than full release because emoji visuals lack the "wow" of polished art.

Buildability 9.0 — Web-only, emoji/CSS, no backend beyond Supabase for leaderboard. 1–2 weeks solo with Claude Code. Can reuse forge/blox-fruit-finder patterns.

Monetization 5.5 — Free at launch (K-factor priority). Path to revenue exists (premium skin, "remove ads", patron tier) but secondary.

Combined 7.2 → BUILD NOW.

#2 AXEL: Resonance — FULL RELEASE CANDIDATE

Virality 8.0 — Vector glow + particle effects make the cascade payoff visually spectacular ("supernova" moment). Streamable, screenshot-able. Differentiated visual lane.

Buildability 6.5 — 3–4 weeks solo with vector assets (no commissioned art). Cascade engine + item synergy system + biome content is the bulk of work.

Monetization 7.0 — Premium $9.99–14.99 on Steam (genre precedent: LBL, CloverPit, Slots & Daggers all in this range). Long tail via mobile F2P port (rewarded video). Cosmetic biome packs as DLC.

Combined 7.3 → BUILD after ZERO validates.

#3 AXEL: Tilt — NARRATIVE ALTERNATIVE

Virality 8.0 — Strongest distinct narrative ("rigging the rigged slot"). Anti-casino framing = moral cover + TikTok-policy-friendly + discourse magnet.

Buildability 5.5 — Vector+collage approach but heist UI + heat mechanic adds complexity. 4–6 weeks solo.

Monetization 7.0 — Premium PC + heist-biome DLC, narrative DLC potential.

Combined 6.9 → BUILD if narrative angle tests stronger than cosmic.